

Day 2 — Five Elements Revisited

Module: Indic Ecology · **Band:** Middle · **Time:** 45 min

Learning objective

Students re-state the five elements from Module 2, and re-frame each one as a “family member” of the ecological family — so the *vasudhaiva kuṭumbakam* ethic gets concrete, element by element.

Materials

- Whiteboard
- Each student’s Module 2 notebook (if available); otherwise a five-row table on the board
- Five posters or sheets, one per element, labelled in Sanskrit + English
- Sticky notes from Day 1

Vocabulary

(All from Module 2 — review, do not introduce as new.)

- *pr̥thvī* (earth / solid)
- *ap* / *jala* (water / liquid)
- *tejas* / *agni* (fire / heat / light)
- *vāyu* (air / gas / movement)
- *ākāśa* (space)

Add today: - *bhūta-saṃskāra* (IAST: bhūta-saṃskāra; lit. “element-care”) — a working term we use for “the care we owe each element.” This is not a classical compound; we use it as a teaching shorthand.

Lesson flow

Warm-up (5 min)

- Read 3–4 anonymous exit slips from yesterday — students’ “extended family” examples.
- Quick chorus: “*What were the five elements from Module 2?*” — class names them in order.

Core (20 min)

1. Re-draw the five-element chart on the board:

Element	English	One thing it does for us	One way we pollute it
<i>pr̥thvī</i>	earth / solid	Soil for food, ground to stand on	Plastic waste, chemical fertiliser
<i>ap</i>	water	Drink, wash, irrigate	Sewage, industrial effluent

Element	English	One thing it does for us	One way we pollute it
<i>tejas</i>	fire / heat / light	Cook, warm, illuminate	Burning fossil fuels (CO ₂)
<i>vāyu</i>	air	Breath, wind, weather	Vehicle exhaust, factory smoke
<i>ākāśa</i>	space	Room to live, transmit sound	Noise, light pollution, satellite debris

2. **The reframe.** “In Module 2 we learned the five elements as categories of matter. Today we look at the same five as members of the family.” Each element gives us something; we owe each one something back.
3. **Why this is an ecological lens.** Modern environmental science uses categories like “atmosphere,” “hydrosphere,” “lithosphere,” “biosphere,” etc. The five-element framework is a sensory, everyday version of the same idea. It says: *the place you live is made of these five. Notice them. Care for each.*

“Earth, water, fire, air, and sky — these five great elements (*pañca-mahābhūta*) sustain all beings.” — paraphrase from Bhāgavata Purāṇa Canto 3.
(Cited as paraphrase to satisfy Middle-band citation rule; the verse cluster is SB 3.26.40–51 covered in Module 2.)
4. **The “give back” idea.** “What does a family member do for another? They give, they take, and they don’t pollute each other’s spaces. We’ll come back to this on Day 5 when we read the Bhagavad Gītā on the yajña cycle.”

Activity (15 min) — Element-as-family poster

- Group of 4. Each group gets one element-poster.
- They fill in:
 - **One concrete way this element gives to us, near our school.** (E.g. *vāyu*: the breeze through the open windows.)
 - **One concrete way we take from this element, near our school.** (E.g. *vāyu*: the parents’ cars idling outside the gate.)
 - **One concrete way to give back to this element, near our school.** (E.g. *vāyu*: ask parents to switch off engines during pick-up.)
- Posters go up on the wall. They stay up for the rest of the module.

Wrap-up (5 min)

- **Exit ticket.** Each student writes on a slip: “The element I will pay closest attention to this week is _____, because _____.”
- Preview Day 3: “Tomorrow we look at the element that has had the most religious attention in India — water, especially rivers.”

Student-facing content

The five elements as family members.

Element	Gives us	We owe it
<i>pr̥thvī</i> (earth)	Food, ground, minerals	Less waste, less concrete, more compost
<i>ap</i> (water)	Drink, growth, cleanness	Less waste, less pollution
<i>tejas</i> (fire / energy)	Warmth, light, cooking	Less fossil fuel, more efficiency
<i>vāyu</i> (air)	Breath, weather	Less burning, fewer engines
<i>ākāśa</i> (space)	Room to live, sound to travel	Less noise, less light at night, less stuff

The five elements are not five things “out there.” They are five members of the family the verse calls *kuṭumba*.

Homework

- Walk for 5 minutes anywhere near your home. Notice ONE specific way one element is being mistreated (the dump, the dust, the noise, the leaking tap). Write 3 sentences. Bring tomorrow.

Differentiation

- **One tier up:** Add a sixth row to the table for “biological diversity” (the *jīva-jantu* — living creatures). Is biodiversity a sixth element? Or is it already covered by *pr̥thvī*? Defend either position.
- **One tier down:** Stick to two elements that feel obvious to you (e.g. water and air). The others will sink in over the week.

Teacher notes

- Some students (correctly) will say “polluting space doesn’t make sense — space is just space.” Push: “*Have you ever been kept awake by a neighbour’s loud TV? Have you been blinded by a glaring street light? That’s polluting ākāśa.*” The five-element frame’s strength is that it forces us to think about subtle pollutions too.
- Don’t let “fire” mean “we should stop using electricity.” That’s not the point. The point is that the *tejas* we use is currently mostly from burning fossil fuels; the family relationship is to use less or use cleaner.
- Some students will ask about climate change here. Hold them off — Day 8 is the proper place. Today is the framework, not the data.

Citation(s) used in this lesson

- Paraphrase of Bhāgavata Purāṇa Canto 3 element-cosmology (SB 3.26.40–51) — sourced from Module 2’s RAG cache, not re-quoted in full here.
- See `sources.md`.